

❖ STUDY BEES ❖

POEM – TRAVEL

by
Robert Louis Stevenson

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About the Poem

"Travel" is a poem by Robert Louis Stevenson from his 1885 collection *A Child's Garden of Verses*. Spoken in the voice of a child, it imagines all the distant, exotic corners of the world the speaker would like to visit one day – tropical islands, Eastern bazaars, the Great Wall of China, vast forests, the River Nile, and a mysterious deserted desert city – before ending with the child's firm resolve to actually travel to these places once grown up. This booklet divides the poem's long, flowing lines into eight natural sections for closer study.

Paraphrasing

Stanza 1:

*I should like to rise and go
Where the golden apples grow;—
Where below another sky
Parrot islands anchored lie,
And, watched by cockatoos and goats,
Lonely Crusoes building boats;—*

Paraphrasing:

The speaker begins by expressing a longing to travel far away, to a place where magical "golden apples" grow. He imagines tropical islands under a different sky, watched over by parrots and goats, where solitary castaways (like the fictional Robinson Crusoe) build boats to escape their islands.

Stanza 2:

*Where in sunshine reaching out
Eastern cities, miles about,
Are with mosque and minaret
Among sandy gardens set,
And the rich goods from near and far
Hang for sale in the bazaar,—*

Paraphrasing:

He imagines grand Eastern cities stretching for miles under bright sunshine, filled with mosques and their tall minaret towers set among sandy gardens. In the bustling marketplaces ("bazaars"), valuable goods from many distant places are displayed and sold.

Stanza 3:

*Where the Great Wall round China goes,
And on one side the desert blows,
And with bell and voice and drum
Cities on the other hum;—*

Paraphrasing:

He pictures the Great Wall of China, with desert winds blowing on one side, while on the other side, lively cities buzz with the sounds of bells, human voices, and drums.

Stanza 4:

*Where are forests, hot as fire,
Wide as England, tall as a spire,
Full of apes and cocoa-nuts
And the huts of local hunters;—*

Paraphrasing:

He imagines vast, steaming tropical forests – as wide as the whole of England and as tall as a church spire – filled with monkeys, coconuts, and the dwellings of the hunters who live there.

Stanza 5:

*Where the knotty crocodile
Lies and blinks in the Nile,
And the red flamingo flies
Hunting fish before his eyes;—*

Paraphrasing:

He pictures the River Nile, where a rough-skinned crocodile lies still, blinking slowly, while a red flamingo flies overhead, hunting for fish.

Stanza 6:

*Where in jungles, near and far,
Man-devouring tigers are,
Lying close and giving ear
Lest the hunt be drawing near,
Or a comer-by be seen
Swinging in a palanquin;—*

Paraphrasing:

He imagines dangerous jungles filled with man-eating tigers, crouched low and listening carefully in case a hunting party approaches, or in case a traveller passes by being carried along in a palanquin (a covered, carried chair).

Stanza 7:

*Where among the desert sands
Some deserted city stands,
All its children, sweep and prince,
Grown to manhood ages since,
Not a foot in street or house,
Not a stir of child or mouse,
And when kindly falls the night,
In all the town no spark of light.*

Paraphrasing:

He imagines a mysterious, abandoned city buried among desert sands, whose inhabitants – rich and poor alike, from street-sweepers to princes – all grew up and left long ago. Now there is no movement of any person or creature in its streets, and when night falls, not a single light appears anywhere in the empty town.

Stanza 8:

*There I'll come when I'm a man
With a camel caravan;
Light a fire in the gloom
Of some dusty dining-room;
See the pictures on the walls,
Heroes, fights and festivals;
And in a corner find the toys
Of the old Egyptian boys.*

Paraphrasing:

The poem closes with the speaker resolving that he will actually travel to this deserted city once he is grown, arriving with a camel caravan. He imagines lighting a fire inside one of its dark, dusty rooms, admiring old wall paintings of heroes, battles, and festivals, and discovering, in a corner, the forgotten toys once played with by children long ago.

Rhyming Scheme

The poem is written in a continuous flow of rhyming couplets (AABBCC and so on), mostly in octosyllabic (eight-syllable) lines. Each pair of lines rhymes before moving on to a new rhyming pair, giving the poem a steady, bouncy, sing-song rhythm well suited to its origins in *A Child's Garden of Verses* and to its subject: a child's excited, ongoing list of imagined destinations.

Theme

“Travel” celebrates the boundless imagination and wanderlust of childhood. Through a long, vivid catalogue of exotic, far-off places, Stevenson captures a child's romantic longing to explore the wide world beyond their own home. The poem's ending, in which the child resolves to actually visit these places “when I'm a

man,” suggests that such early, imaginative wonder can grow into genuine, lifelong curiosity and a real desire to travel and discover the world firsthand.

Figures of Speech

- **Anaphora**

The repeated word “Where” begins section after section, structuring the poem as a long, building catalogue of imagined places.

- **Imagery**

Rich, exotic visual imagery – mosques and minarets, the Great Wall, crocodiles on the Nile, tigers in the jungle – brings each imagined destination vividly to life.

- **Hyperbole / Simile**

Forests are exaggeratedly described as “hot as fire,” “wide as England,” and “tall as a spire,” emphasising their awe-inspiring scale through the child's imagination.

- **Personification**

The crocodile “lies and blinks,” and cities “hum” with sound, giving the landscape a sense of life and activity.

- **Cataloguing / Listing**

The poem's long list-like structure conveys the sheer scope and variety of the child's imagined travels around the world.

- **Alliteration**

Phrases such as “bell and voice” and “sweep and prince” use repeated sounds to add rhythm and musicality.

- **Shift in Tone / Resolution**

The final section shifts from imagined wishing (“I should like...”) to firm resolve (“There I'll come when I'm a man...”), showing the child's fantasy maturing into a genuine future goal.

Questions & Answers

Q1. What effect does the repeated word “Where” create throughout the poem?

It creates a long, list-like catalogue of many different faraway places the speaker imagines visiting, conveying the vast scope of a child's imagination.

Q2. What kinds of places does the speaker imagine in the poem?

Tropical islands with castaways, Eastern cities with mosques and bazaars, the Great Wall of China, vast forests, the River Nile with crocodiles and flamingos, tiger-filled jungles, and a mysterious deserted desert city.

Q3. What is unusual or striking about the deserted city described near the end of the poem?

It is completely empty and silent – all its former inhabitants grew up and left long ago, leaving “not a stir of child or mouse” and no light anywhere once night falls, giving it a mysterious, timeless quality.

Q4. How does the poem's tone shift in the final section?

It shifts from imagined wishing ("I should like to rise and go") to firm resolve ("There I'll come when I'm a man"), showing the child's fantasy turning into a genuine intended goal.

Q5. What poetic device is used in "forests, hot as fire, / Wide as England, tall as a spire"?

Hyperbole and simile – exaggerated comparisons that emphasise the awe-inspiring scale of the imagined forests.

Q6. What does the mention of a "camel caravan" in the final stanza suggest?

It suggests the classic, exotic mode of desert travel the speaker imagines using to actually reach the deserted city once he is grown.

Q7. What is the central theme of the poem?

The poem celebrates a child's imaginative wanderlust and longing to explore far-off, exotic parts of the world, blending fantasy with a genuine hope of future travel.